

GovCon BD Upskilling Program

Contracting Readiness

Module 4.2 | Domains D5 + D6 (22%)

DURATION

2-2.5 hours

FORMAT

Live Instructor-Led

GovConGiants

30-Day Foundation Program

Module 4.2: Contracting Readiness

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, learners will be able to:

1. **Identify** key contractor registrations and certifications required for federal contracting
2. **Explain** basic FAR compliance requirements relevant to BD activities
3. **Describe** small business certification programs and their advantages
4. **Recognize** internal handoff processes between BD, capture, and execution teams
5. **Understand** key growth metrics used to track BD/capture effectiveness

Required Reading/Viewing

Official Government Resources (Free)

1. **SAM.gov** - Entity Registration
 - URL: <https://sam.gov/content/entity-registration>
 - Focus: Understanding registration requirements
2. **SBA.gov** - Small Business Certifications
 - URL: <https://www.sba.gov/federal-contracting/contracting-assistance-programs>
 - Focus: Certification programs overview
3. **FAR Part 4** - Administrative Matters
 - URL: <https://www.acquisition.gov/far/part-4>
 - Focus: Contractor registration requirements

Action Plan Journal References

- **Part 1: Company Setup and Necessary Registration:** pages 11-29
- **Set Up Supplier Trade Accounts:** page 12
- **Identify NAICS Codes:** pages 14-15
- **Company Website and Email:** pages 16-17
- **Capability Statement:** pages 18-19
- **Small Business Certifications:** pages 20-23
- **DUNS and Bradstreet Number:** pages 24-25

- **SAM.gov - Create Your Login.gov Account:** pages 26-27
- **Create DSBS Profile:** pages 28-29
- **Part 1 Progress Review:** pages 30-31

Lesson Content

1. Why Contracting Readiness Matters

Before you can win federal contracts, your company must be “ready” to do business with the government. This means:

- **Registration:** Active in required systems
- **Certifications:** Verified small business status (if applicable)
- **Compliance:** Meeting FAR requirements
- **Infrastructure:** Systems and processes in place

Key Insight

Lack of readiness can disqualify you from opportunities or delay awards. Being ready before opportunities arise is critical.

2. Essential Contractor Registrations

SAM.gov Registration

What: System for Award Management - the official government database for contractor registration.

Why Required: You cannot receive a federal contract without an active SAM registration.

Key Elements:

UEI	Unique Entity Identifier - replaced DUNS number
CAGE Code	Commercial and Government Entity code
NAICS Codes	Industry codes you operate under
Size Status	Small business determination by NAICS
Reps & Certs	Representations and certifications

Core Data	Company information, POCs, banking
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Registration Requirements:

- Must be renewed annually
- Must be active at time of award
- Updates required for any changes
- Free to register

Status Check: Go to SAM.gov → Entity Search → Search your company

Other Key Registrations

SAM.gov	Entity registration	All contractors
DSBS	Small business profile	Small businesses
WAWF	Invoice submission	All contractors
eSRS	Subcontracting reports	Large businesses
CPARS	Past performance database	All contractors (receiving ratings)

3. Small Business Certifications

Small business certifications provide competitive advantages through set-aside contracts.

SBA Certification Programs

8(a)	Socially and economically disadvantaged	Sole source up to \$4.5M (services), set-asides
HUBZone	Located in Historically Underutilized Business Zone	Set-asides, price evaluation preference
WOSB	Women-owned (51%+)	Set-asides in underrepresented industries
EDWOSB	Economically disadvantaged women-owned	Set-asides in all industries

SDVOSB	Service-disabled veteran-owned (51%+)	Set-asides, VA priority
VOSB	Veteran-owned (51%+)	VA set-asides

Self-Certification vs. SBA Certification

Self-Certified	WOSB (some), small business status	Declare in SAM.gov; subject to protest
SBA-Certified	8(a), HUBZone, SDVOSB, EDWOSB	SBA reviews and certifies; stronger protection

Note

Self-certification is easier but more vulnerable to challenges. SBA certification provides stronger standing.

4. FAR Basics for BD Professionals

The **Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR)** governs all federal procurement. You don't need to be a FAR expert, but understanding key concepts helps.

Key FAR Concepts

Part 2	Definitions	Common terminology
Part 9	Contractor Qualifications	Responsibility, debarment
Part 15	Contracting by Negotiation	Proposal process, evaluation
Part 16	Contract Types	FFP, T&M, CPFF, IDIQ
Part 19	Small Business Programs	Set-asides, certifications

Common Contract Types

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FFP	Firm Fixed Price	Contractor bears cost risk	Well-defined re-requirements
T&M	Time and Materials	Government bears cost risk	Uncertain scope
CPFF	Cost Plus Fixed Fee	Shared risk	R&D, complex work
IDIQ	Indefinite Delivery/Indefinite Quantity	Varies by task order	Ongoing needs, flexibility
BPA	Blanket Purchase Agreement	Varies	Recurring purchases

5. Internal Handoffs: BD to Delivery

Winning a contract is only half the battle. Smooth transition from BD/capture to program execution is critical.

The Handoff Challenge

Customer pain points	How to address them operationally
Win themes promised	How to deliver on those promises
Key personnel committed	Staffing plan execution
Pricing assumptions	Actual cost management
Competitor weaknesses exploited	Performance standards to meet

Key Handoff Documents

Transition Plan	How to start up without disruption
Staffing Plan	Who, when, and how they'll be onboarded

Risk Register	Known risks from capture phase
Key Customer Contacts	Relationships to transfer
Pricing Basis	Assumptions behind the numbers
Technical Solution	What was proposed
Compliance Matrix	Requirements we committed to

Handoff Meeting Agenda (Example)

1. Contract overview and key dates
2. Customer expectations and pain points
3. Win themes and promises made
4. Key personnel and their roles
5. Pricing assumptions and constraints
6. Known risks and issues
7. Critical first 30/60/90 day actions
8. Questions and clarifications

6. Growth Metrics: Measuring BD Effectiveness

Tracking the right metrics helps leadership understand BD/capture performance and make better decisions.

Pipeline Metrics

Pipeline Value	Total \$ of opportunities being pursued	3-5x annual revenue
Win Rate	% of submitted proposals that win	30-50%
Capture Rate	% of qualified opportunities that win	25-40%
Proposal Volume	# of proposals submitted	Varies
Average Deal Size	\$ per contract won	Varies

Activity Metrics

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Customer Meetings	# of customer engagements per month
RFI Responses	# of market research responses
Industry Days Attended	Engagement activity
Teaming Discussions	Partnership activity
Saved Searches	Opportunity monitoring

Win/Loss Analysis

After every decision (win or loss), capture lessons learned:

Why did we win/lose?	Root cause
What did the winner do better?	Competitive positioning
What feedback did we get?	Debrief intel
What would we do differently?	Process improvement
Is there a recompetete opportunity?	Future pipeline

7. Staying Ready: Ongoing Activities

Contracting readiness isn't a one-time event—it requires ongoing maintenance.

Annual/Regular Tasks:

SAM.gov renewal	Annual	Contracts
Certification renewal	Per program	Contracts
NAICS code review	Annual	BD/Contracts
Past performance documentation	Ongoing	Program/BD
Capability statement update	Quarterly	BD/Marketing
Contract vehicle review	Annual	Contracts

AI Accelerator: Using AI for Contracting Readiness

AI tools can help you understand FAR requirements, draft compliance documents, and analyze BD metrics.

Prompt 1: Explain FAR Clauses

Use When: You encounter a FAR clause you don't understand.

Explain this FAR clause in plain language:

[PASTE FAR CLAUSE OR REFERENCE NUMBER]

Provide:

1. What this clause requires from contractors
2. Why this clause exists (purpose)
3. Common compliance issues to avoid
4. How this might affect proposal or contract execution
5. Any related clauses I should also review

Explain at a level appropriate for someone new to government contracting.

Prompt 2: Understand Certification Requirements

Use When: You're exploring small business certifications.

Explain the requirements and benefits of [CERTIFICATION TYPE: 8(a) / HUBZone / WOSB / EDWOSB / SDVOSB] certification:

1. Eligibility requirements
2. Application process overview
3. Contracting benefits (set-asides, sole source thresholds)
4. Ongoing compliance requirements
5. Common reasons applications are denied
6. How long certification lasts
7. Agencies most active in using this set-aside

We are a [BRIEF COMPANY DESCRIPTION]. Would we likely qualify?

Prompt 3: Analyze BD Metrics

Use When: You need to interpret BD performance data.

Analyze these BD metrics and provide insights:

Pipeline Data:

- Total pipeline value: [AMOUNT]
- Number of opportunities: [COUNT]
- Win rate: [PERCENTAGE]

Provide:

1. Pipeline health assessment
2. Win rate analysis vs. industry benchmarks
3. Areas of concern
4. Recommendations for improvement

Pro Tips for AI-Assisted Contracting Readiness

Use AI to explain FAR clauses	Take AI legal interpretations as final
Draft capability statements with AI	Share sensitive company data publicly
Get AI help understanding certifications	Let AI make certification decisions
Create handoff templates with AI	Skip human review of compliance docs

■ Applied Exercise: Complete a Readiness Checklist

Scenario: Your manager asks you to assess your company's contracting readiness and identify any gaps that need attention.

Part 1: Verify SAM.gov Registration

1. Go to SAM.gov
2. Search for your company (or a company you're familiar with)
3. Note registration status and expiration date
4. Identify NAICS codes listed

Part 2: Review Certifications

1. Go to SBA.gov certification programs
2. Identify which certifications your company holds (or could pursue)
3. Note expiration dates and renewal requirements

Part 3: Complete the Readiness Checklist

Use the Work Artifact template to assess readiness and identify gaps.

Time: 30-45 minutes

Work Artifact: Contracting Readiness Checklist

Header

Your Name: _____

Date: _____

Company Name: _____

Section 1: Registration Status

SAM.gov	Active / Inactive		
UEI	Valid / Unknown		
CAGE Code	Valid / Unknown		
DSBS Profile	Active / None		

Section 2: NAICS Codes Registered

Section 3: Small Business Certifications

8(a)	Yes / No / Pending		
HUBZone	Yes / No / Pending		
WOSB	Yes / No / Pending		
EDWOSB	Yes / No / Pending		
SDVOSB	Yes / No / Pending		
VOSB	Yes / No / Pending		

Section 4: Key Documents Status

Capability Statement	Current / Needs Update		
Past Performance Database	Current / Needs Update		
Key Personnel Resumes	Current / Needs Update		
Org Chart	Current / Needs Update		
Rate Sheets	Current / Needs Update		

Section 5: Gap Analysis

	High / Med / Low		
	High / Med / Low		
	High / Med / Low		

Section 6: Growth Metrics Tracking

Pipeline Value	\$	\$	

Win Rate	%	%	
# Active Pursuits			
# Proposals YTD			
# Wins YTD			

Knowledge Check (Self-Assessment)

Question 1 (Recall)

What is required for a company to receive a federal contract award?

- A) Only a capability statement
- B) **Active SAM.gov registration**
- C) Past performance only
- D) GSA Schedule

Correct Answer: B

Question 2 (Application)

Your company's SAM.gov registration expires next month. What happens if it lapses?

- A) Nothing—it auto-renews
- B) **You cannot receive new contract awards until renewed**
- C) Current contracts are automatically cancelled
- D) You get a 90-day grace period

Correct Answer: B

Question 3 (Recall)

Which small business certification allows sole-source contracts up to \$4.5M for services?

- A) HUBZone
- B) WOSB
- C) **8(a)**
- D) SDVOSB

Correct Answer: C

Question 4 (Scenario)

Your BD team has a 10% win rate and leadership is concerned. What should you investigate first?

- A) Just submit more proposals
- B) **Analyze loss reasons to identify patterns**
- C) Lower all prices by 20%
- D) Stop pursuing opportunities

Correct Answer: B

Question 5 (Recall)

What is the recommended pipeline value relative to annual revenue for a healthy BD operation?

- A) Equal to annual revenue
- B) **3-5x annual revenue**
- C) 10x annual revenue
- D) Pipeline size doesn't matter

Correct Answer: B

Manager Discussion Prompts

1. **Current Context:** "Is our company's SAM.gov registration current? What certifications do we hold, and who manages them?"
2. **Application:** "What metrics does our company use to track BD/capture performance? How can I contribute to keeping those metrics healthy?"
3. **Career Development:** "What aspects of contracting readiness or compliance would be valuable for me to understand better?"

Completion Criteria

To complete this module:

- ☐ Read all required materials (approximately 20 minutes)
- ☐ Complete the lesson content review (30-45 minutes)
- ☐ Finish the Applied Exercise (verify registrations and complete checklist)
- ☐ Submit a Contracting Readiness Checklist with gap analysis
- ☐ Review the Knowledge Check questions (self-assessment)
- ☐ Participate in manager discussion (or document self-reflection)

Estimated Total Time: 2-2.5 hours

Additional Resources

Key Registration and Certification Links

SAM.gov Registration	sam.gov/content/entity-registration
SBA Certifications	sba.gov/federal-contracting/contracting-assistance-programs
8(a) Program	sba.gov/federal-contracting/contracting-assistance-programs/8a-business-development-program
HUBZone Program	sba.gov/federal-contracting/contracting-assistance-programs/hubzone-program
WOSB Program	sba.gov/federal-contracting/contracting-assistance-programs/women-owned-small-business-federal-contracting-program
SDVOSB Certification	sba.gov/federal-contracting/contracting-assistance-programs/veteran-contracting-assistance-programs

Key Terms

UEI: Unique Entity Identifier - replaced DUNS number

CAGE Code: Commercial and Government Entity code

SAM.gov: System for Award Management - required registration

FAR: Federal Acquisition Regulation

FFP: Firm Fixed Price contract type

T&M: Time and Materials contract type

IDIQ: Indefinite Delivery/Indefinite Quantity

Pipeline: Collection of opportunities being tracked/pursued

Win Rate: Percentage of submitted proposals that win

Action Plan Journal Activities

After completing this module, use your **Action Plan Journal** to:

1. Complete **Part 1 Initial Assessment** (page 10) to verify all company setup items
2. Work through **Part 1: Company Setup and Necessary Registration** (pages 11-29)
3. Use the **NAICS Codes Worksheet** (pages 14-15) to verify your codes
4. Update your **Capability Statement** using the checklist (pages 18-19)
5. Review **Small Business Certifications** status (pages 20-23)
6. Complete the **Part 1 Progress Review** (pages 30-31)

Journal Reference

The Contracting Readiness Checklist you completed should be compared against Part 1 of your Action Plan Journal. Any gaps identified should be added to your Progress Review for tracking.

Program Completion

Congratulations on completing the 30-Day Foundation modules!

What You've Learned

1.1 GovCon Market Overview	Federal market size, agency structure, budget cycles
1.2 Buyer Intelligence	SAM.gov Contract Data, spending patterns, incumbent research
2.1 Opportunity Discovery	SAM.gov, opportunity types, qualification
2.2 Customer Engagement	OSDBU, industry days, capability briefings
3.1 BD Process Fundamentals	BD lifecycle, pipeline stages, teaming
3.2 Competitive Positioning	Win themes, discriminators, competitor analysis
4.1 Proposal Support	Compliance matrix, RFP structure, supporting proposals
4.2 Contracting Readiness	Registrations, certifications, metrics

Your Artifacts

Over the 30 days, you created:

- Market Overview Worksheet
- Agency Research Report
- Opportunity Log (10 opportunities)
- Customer Engagement Plan
- BD Process Map
- Competitive Brief
- Compliance Matrix
- Contracting Readiness Checklist

Next Steps

1. **Apply what you've learned** to your daily work
2. **Connect with your BD/capture team** to offer support
3. **Keep your saved searches active** on SAM.gov
4. **Continue building industry knowledge** through events and research
5. **Consider advanced training** (60-Day Practitioner or 90-Day Professional)